

about the lives of women. Famous examples include Charlotte Brontë's *Jane Eyre* (published under the pseudonym Currer Bell) and her sister Emily Brontë's *Wuthering Heights* (Ellis Bell) in 1847. Another successful novelist, Mary Anne Evans, insisted upon the pseudonym George Eliot for her novels, such as *Middlemarch* (1872), partly to deflect scandal about her living openly with a married man separated from his wife.

Over time it became more acceptable for women to write under their own names. Edith Wharton and Kate Chopin wrote works dissecting the worlds they inhabited in late 19th- and early 20th-century America. Wharton's *The House of Mirth* (1905) and *The Age of Innocence* (1920) explore the lives of high society women in New York. Chopin was from Louisiana, and her stories address the racism affecting the mixed-race milieu of the South due to slavery. Later, *Beloved* (1987) by Toni Morrison was inspired by the true story of African American slave Margaret Garner.

Pushing the boundaries

The 20th-century postcolonial era has seen a significant rise in writing by women from Africa. *Une si Longue Lettre* (*So Long a Letter*) (1979) by Mariama Bâ from Senegal, thought to be the first African feminist novel, explores the experiences of African Muslim women. Modern female writers have also begun to explore new techniques and cover more controversial subjects, from politics to sexuality to mental health. Margaret Atwood exposes women's subjugation within a patriarchal society in *The Handmaid's Tale*, while Janet Frame's autobiography *An Angel at My Table* (1984) discusses her experiences of mental illness and shock therapy in New Zealand.

Not all societies enjoy such freedom of expression, however. In China, Ding Ling's work was banned in the Anti-Rightist movement of 1957 and during the Cultural Revolution (1966–76). It was finally republished in 1978.



▲ Slave poet

This portrait of poet Phillis Wheatley shows her writing with a quill pen. Despite living as an African slave, Wheatley was one of the best known poets in pre 19th-century America. She wrote her first published poem at around the age of 13.



PROFILES

WOMEN WORDSMITHS

Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz (c.1651–1695) chose to become a nun in 1667. The patronage of the viceroy and vicerine of New Spain gave her the freedom to pursue her writing and learning. In 1691 she wrote a defense of all women's right to knowledge—the *Respuesta a Sor Filotea de la Cruz* (Reply to Sister Filotea of the Cross). Her best-known poem is *Primero sueño* (1692).

Annette von Droste-Hülshoff (1797–1848) grew up in Münster in an intellectual circle that included the Brothers Grimm, Adele and Johanna Schopenhauer, and Friedrich Schlegel. One of the foremost women in German literature, her best-known work is the Gothic murder-mystery, *Die Judenbuche* (*The Jew's Beech*, 1842).

Higuchi Ichiyō (1872–1896) was famed in her lifetime in 19th-century Japan, both for her talents and for the novelty of being a successful female writer. She wrote stories and poems in order to support her very poor family. Her main characters are nearly always women and outcasts, such as orphans, divorcees, and prostitutes. Her stories include *Takekurabe* (*Growing Up*, 1895).

Miles Franklin (1879–1954) grew up as Stella Franklin in a pioneer farming family on the edge of the Australian Alps in New South Wales. She wrote her first novel, *My Brilliant Career* (1901), when she was only 16, in just a couple of weeks. She wanted her female identity to remain a secret, so she did not use her real name as a writer. Named in her honor, the Miles Franklin Award is Australia's most prestigious literary prize.

Maya Angelou (1928–2014) wrote a much-loved memoir about her early childhood in America's south, *I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings* (1969), the first of seven "autobiographical fictions" chronicling her extraordinary life experiences as a woman, poet, singer, and civil rights activist. She was also highly respected as a spokesperson for African Americans.

Margaret Atwood (b.1939) is the Canadian author of *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985) and the Booker prize-winning *The Blind Assassin* (2000), her best-known novels. Her achievements reach beyond the literary, and she is also well-known and respected for her environmental activism.